

Who really gets onto the list? Immediate family, sure. Aunts and uncles? Maybe. Coworkers? Depends. Friends? That's when things get problematic. Scan that list with a vicious eye. You're an accountant first, a blushing bride later. If you've known these friends for five, ten years, maybe that's your cutoff. Maybe you invite only people who are friends with both you and your betrothed. Pay particular attention to cousins. Do you really care if they're at your wedding? Another cost saved.

Savings: \$2,000–\$10,000-plus.

7. **Don't scrimp on the booze.** This is the only place you don't want to cut costs. Booze should flow from the minute your guests arrive until the minute you insist on pouring them into a cab. It may seem counterintuitive and "off message," but I promise you this: When people have a couple of drinks, they're less picky. They likely won't notice the crappy DJ, the balloons in lieu of flowers, or the fact that it's all taking place on Thursday night.

Savings: None.

8. **Bring back money rituals.** Italians have it right. I like how they shop, and I like how they celebrate big events with cold hard cash. Had a baby? Here's some money. Communion time? Whom do I make this check out to? Getting married? Here's a fat envelope for the basket. It's always about money. Unlike knickknacks, baubles, and trinkets, money adds pageantry and permanence to any occasion. When you give money, you're saying, "Here, I'm investing in your love, your goals, your future. I want prosperity for you. Let me contribute." Giving someone a blender just says, "I don't know you very well, but good luck."

Savings: \$3,000–\$10,000-plus.

9. **Ban the bridesmaids.** Skip the wedding party. Having just a maid of honor and a best man means they won't have to spend a lot of money on their own outfits. And you won't have to blow a wad on gifts thanking them for going broke on behalf of